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SPECIAL ISSUE INTRODUCTION

Social Cohesion in (Post-)Conflict and Divided Societies: Recent Advances and Future Directions

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ABSTRACT

Although the study of social cohesion in divided and (post-)conflict societies has grown steadily within social psychology over the past decades, researchers also argue that addressing social cohesion is a complex task due to its multidimensional and multilevel nature. With this special thematic section, we aim to advance the understanding of the dynamics of social cohesion across contexts marked by deep social divisions and intergroup tensions where achieving social cohesion can be particularly challenging. We also seek to showcase research examining different dimensions of social cohesion and explore how such analyses can inform efforts to foster cohesion and improve intra- and intergroup relations. This special thematic section brings together nine empirical articles, drawing on both quantitative and qualitative methods, conducted in diverse, divided and (post-)conflict contexts, and incorporating both majority and minority groups' perspectives. Together, these contributions highlight the factors that can foster or hinder social cohesion within specific societies. By building on the findings from these contributions, we outline avenues for future research to further advance knowledge on social cohesion in divided and (post-)conflict societies.

1 | Introduction

Across the world, many societies have faced and continue to face increasing levels of conflict, polarization, inequality and social division, making social cohesion difficult to maintain or achieve. Challenges such as climate change, new migration dynamics, growing social and economic inequalities and the rise of authoritarian, populist and extreme right-wing political parties have all placed strains on the social fabric of communities.

Although these issues affect societies globally, examining social cohesion in contexts marked by deep social divides and/or (post-)conflict dynamics can offer insights into how social cohesion can take different forms and may be strengthened or undermined over time. Divided and post-conflict societies often face persistent challenges linked to divisions along ethnic, national, religious, sectarian or racial lines, among others. What distinguishes these societies from others is not only the depth of such divisions but also the difficulty, or even inability, to agree on shared decision-making processes, to coexist peacefully and to forge common identities or mutual acceptance among groups. These challenges make social cohesion particularly hard to achieve.

We argue that understanding the specific psychosocial dynamics and identities that emerge and interact in these contexts is essential for addressing both current and future challenges to cohesion. In our approach, the term 'divided society' refers not only to places usually known as ongoing or post-conflict societies such as Cyprus or Northern Ireland but also to societies that may be relatively free of active conflict and geographical divisions yet remain deeply divided, for example, across political lines, as in Chile or Hong Kong.

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For this reason, in this special thematic section, we address the different ways in which social cohesion is understood across various contexts and what promotes and prevents it in (post-)conflict and divided societies. Some of the more specific questions guiding this collection include: What is the role of national/religious/ethnic identities in conflicts? What divides and unites us? How can we tackle the problems of division in society? What kind of interventions and policies may be useful? What is the role of narratives or shared representations of conflict and victimhood in ongoing or post-conflict societies? What are the social-psychological effects of these divisions on individuals and groups? This special thematic section brings together research on the dynamics of social cohesion from diverse contexts around the world such as Northern Ireland, Serbia, Lebanon and Burkina Faso, among others. These nine contributions advance our understanding of how such societies manage the complex group and interpersonal dynamics as well as intergroup relations across a wide range of divided and (post-)conflict societies.

In the following sections, we first present a brief overview of the theorizing and literature on social cohesion and its links to different social-psychological variables and processes. In doing so, we aim to highlight the diversity of ways in which the concept has been defined over time, as well as the difficulties of defining and operationalizing such a complex construct. We then introduce previous research that has analysed different barriers to social cohesion across time and contexts. After this, we briefly introduce each of the manuscripts included in this special thematic section, highlighting the diverse ways in which social cohesion is addressed, the specific correlates examined in each context and the similarities and differences in the approaches taken by the contributing authors. Finally, we conclude this introduction by providing directions for future research on social cohesion in divided and (post-)conflict societies.

1.1 | Social Cohesion: Conceptual Challenges and Core Components

The Social Cohesion Hub defines social cohesion as 'the quality of social cooperation and togetherness in a territorially delimited community' (2025, n.a.). In a different vein, Grimalda and Tänzler (2018) propose that it includes both an objective component, which concerns the predisposition of individuals to connect and interact with others and to participate at the political and civic level, and a subjective component which focuses on perceived trust at the social and institutional level.

Within the social sciences, and particularly in social and political psychology, the concept is often used without a clear or concrete definition, and there is still no consensus on what social cohesion truly means or how it can be fully operationalized and analysed (e.g., Ariely 2014; Aruqaj 2023; Jenson 2010; Klein 2013; Ranci 2011; OECD 2024; Social Cohesion Hub 2025). In this light, different scholars have argued that social cohesion is frequently conflated with its main drivers and effects and have called for a sharper differentiation between the concept of social cohesion and its antecedents and outcomes, along with greater efforts to refine its operationalization and measurement. This would allow for a more precise understanding of what social cohesion is and what it is not (e.g., Aruqaj 2023; Social Cohesion Hub 2025; Schiefer and van der Noll 2017; Social Cohesion Hub 2025). Moving beyond vague or general definitions is, therefore, essential for understanding the dynamics of conflict in contemporary societies (Aruqaj 2023; Dragolov et al. 2016; Schiefer and van der Noll 2017), both in academic research and political debates.

Other authors (e.g., Social Cohesion Hub 2025; Castillo et al. 2022; Schiefer and van der Noll 2017) have emphasized its multidimensional and multilevel nature, focusing on the domains that best capture its presence within a social entity, such as a society. For example, the Social Cohesion Hub (2025) proposes three key dimensions: (1) social relations, (2) connectedness and (3) a focus on the common good. Schiefer and van der Noll (2017) offer a similar model highlighting positive social relations, feeling attachment or a sense of belonging to a specific context and/or social identity and an orientation towards the common good. Castillo et al. (2022) build on these dimensions by adding a further dimension: (positive) territorial bonds. In this special thematic section, we will use these four broad dimensions—social relations, connectedness or belonging, orientation towards the common good and territorial bonds—as a guiding framework for highlighting the diversity of social cohesion understandings reflected in the nine contributions. This approach allows us to link each article's operationalization of cohesion to a shared conceptual structure while recognizing the contextual specificities of divided and (post-)conflict societies.

In this special thematic section, we showcase recent research that engages with social cohesion through different theoretical perspectives and methodological approaches. Before describing these contributions, we turn to different barriers to social cohesion that have been identified in various contexts, with a particular focus on divided and (post-)conflict societies.

1.2 | Barriers to Social Cohesion

Social cohesion has been widely discussed in recent decades in both academic and political spheres (Arant et al. 2021). A major reason for this attention is the idea that cohesive societies tend to be more resilient, have higher levels of well-being, experience lower inequality and achieve higher economic growth (United Nations Economic Commission for Europe—UNECE 2023). In contrast, cohesion can be weakened by factors such as rising social and economic inequality and the erosion of social bonds (Pickett et al. 2024).

Several reports over the past two decades have alerted to signs of declining social cohesion in different parts of the world (e.g., Council of Europe 2005; Grimalda and Tänzler 2018; Jenson 1998; Schmeets and te Riele 2014). The reasons identified for this decline vary. Some relate to divisions stemming from income inequality, diversity, language, gender and other sociodemographic differences (Grimalda and Tänzler 2018). Economic changes linked to globalization have also been cited, with authors arguing that they undermine social bonds and challenge community stability (e.g., Chan et al. 2006; Chiesi 2004; Han et al. 2012). Migration and increasing diversity of contemporary societies have likewise been identified as threats to social cohesion (e.g., Ariely 2014; Cheong et al. 2007; Huntington 2004; O'Donnell et al. 2024; Putnam 2007; Schaeffer 2016; Wickes

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et al. 2014). However, other researchers have noted that diversity can foster cohesion under specific conditions (e.g., Alexiu and Sordé 2011; Ariely 2014; Gijsberts et al. 2012; Moleka 2024).

Another significant factor is the rise of populist, authoritarian and extreme right-wing political parties. These movements have been linked to reduced social trust (e.g., Berning and Ziller 2017), greater social isolation and lower civic engagement (e.g., Rydgren 2009), stronger anti-immigrant and anti-diversity sentiments (e.g., Ivarsflaten 2008; Lubbers et al. 2002), heightened affective and political polarization (e.g., Törnberg 2022; Wardani 2025), nostalgia for a perceived past of stable values (Aruqaj 2023) and more homogenous societies. Together, these developments create conditions that can erode the foundations of social cohesion.

2 | Overview of Contributions

When putting together this special thematic section, our aim was to understand the dynamics of social cohesion within divided and (post-)conflict societies. The final collection of articles reflected this aim by highlighting research conducted in a wide range of contexts: (1) divided societies: Lebanon (Al-Amine et al. 2025), Hong Kong (Hong et al. 2025), Northern Ireland (Këllezi et al. 2024; McKeown et al. 2024), England (McKeown et al. 2024); (2) post-conflict settings: Kosovo (Borinca et al. 2024; Këllezi et al. 2024), Albania (Këllezi et al. 2024), Colombia (Landmann et al. 2025), Serbia (Ivanović et al. 2024); (3) ongoing conflict societies: Sri Lanka (Penić et al. 2024), the Occupied Palestinian Territory (Penić et al. 2024) and Burkina Faso' Sahel Region (Varela et al. 2025).

The contributions use quantitative, qualitative and mixed-methods approaches. Three focus on social cohesion in divided societies (i.e., Lebanon, Hong Kong, Northern Ireland and England), four examine post-conflict contexts (i.e., Kosovo, Northern Ireland, Albania and Colombia) and three address ongoing conflicts (i.e., Sri Lanka, the Occupied Palestinian Territory and Burkina Faso). In most cases, social cohesion is analysed as an outcome or dependent variable, but in two studies (Hong et al. 2025; Varela et al. 2025), it is examined as a predictor variable by exploring its consequences in divided and conflict societies.

Two of the manuscripts focus on youth samples (Ivanović et al. 2024; McKeown et al. 2024), whereas the others draw on adult samples. Table 1 provides an overview of the contributions, including the contexts studied, the theoretical frameworks, methodological approaches, conceptualizations of social cohesion and the predictors (*explanans*) and outcomes (*explanandum*) examined.

To start with, Al-Amine et al. (2025) examine social cohesion in Lebanon after the 2019 uprising. Starting from the premise that both vertical cohesion (state–citizen trust and cooperation) and horizontal cohesion (relations among citizens) have eroded, they examine political polarization between citizens who oppose the ruling parties ('anti-ruling parties' participants) and those who support them ('partisan/aligned' participants). Across two quantitative studies with Lebanese participants, they find that anti-ruling party participants report lower institutional trust, lower sectarianism and stronger support for a secular political system than 'partisan/aligned' participants. Economic grievances, however, do not differ between groups, pointing to a shared dissatisfaction with the economic situation. Mobilization patterns shift over time: In 2020, 'anti-ruling parties' participants show stronger system-challenging collective action orientations, whereas in 2022, they express stronger demobilization intentions (e.g., lower voting intentions and greater migration tendencies). These findings illustrate how political polarization and shifting mobilization tendencies intersect with a broader breakdown of both vertical and horizontal cohesion in Lebanon. Hong et al. (2025) use a survey study with both person- and variable-centred approaches to examine how different indicators of social cohesion (i.e., core values; legitimacy of the political system; and attitudes towards Hong Kong-Mainland China) underlie the different politicized collective identities (Yellow vs. Blue) that emerged during the 2019 social unrest in Hong Kong. Their analysis identifies four latent classes aligned with the Yellow–Blue politicized identities that emerged after the social uprising. Membership in these four classes predicts distinct patterns of collective action intentions and preferred solutions to the political schism, showing how variation in cohesion indicators maps onto identity-based divisions in Hong Kong.

McKeown et al. (2024) present longitudinal research on the effects of contact quantity and quality on dimensions of social cohesion, including outgroup attitudes, empathy, intergroup anxiety and prosocial behaviour. Conducted among youth in two divided contexts, Belfast, Northern Ireland (Protestant vs. Catholic identities) and Bradford, England (White/White English vs. Asian/Asian English identities), the two studies reveal strong between-person differences: Individuals with more frequent and higher quality intergroup contact report more positive intergroup attitudes, lower intergroup anxiety, greater empathy and more prosociality towards outgroups. Nonetheless, the inconsistent findings regarding within-person change over time suggest that shifts in contact experiences do not necessarily lead to changes in specific social cohesion-related outcomes.

Këllezi et al. (2024) examine how perceptions of transitional and social justice (framed as 'holistic justice') relate to the long-term experiences and well-being of survivors of Mass Human Rights Violations (MHRVs). Using a multi-method qualitative approach in three post-conflict contexts (i.e., Kosovo, Northern Ireland and Albania), they find that satisfaction with justice processes is essential for survivors' well-being over time. Survivors' justice needs are multidimensional, highlighting the value of a holistic conception of justice that incorporates human rights perspectives, identity processes and the broader socio-political context. They argue for complex, holistic forms of justice as a foundation for individual and collective well-being and social cohesion in post-conflict societies.

Landmann et al. (2025) analyse the role of intergroup contact, conflict appraisals and emotions in reconciliation in post-conflict Colombia, focusing on contact with former FARC (i.e., the Revolutionary Armed Forces of Colombia) combatants. Across two quantitative studies, they test whether conflict appraisals and the emotions felt serially mediate the relationship between intergroup contact and reconciliation attitudes. Although both intergroup contact and conflict appraisals are independently associated with attitudes towards reconciliation, the hypothe-

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TABLE 1 | Overview of the articles included in this special thematic section.

Authors	Context(s)	Sample(s) and year of data collection	Theoretical approach	Operationalization of social cohesion	Method(s) of analysis	Explanans	Explanandum
Al-Amine, Saab, Harb, and Majed	Divided societal context Lebanon, post-2019 uprising	Study 1: 357 adult Lebanese citizens residing in Lebanon (2020) Study 2: Nationally representative sample of 1200 adult participants (2022)	Social cohesion framework: Citizens' vertical relations (with the state) and horizontal relations (with other citizens)	Study 1: Social political orientations; mobilization tendencies Study 2: Social political orientations; (de)mobilization tendencies	Quantitative: Studies 1 and 2: Surveys	Predictors: Studies 1 and 2: Political partisanship	Study 1: Social political orientations; mobilization tendencies Study 2: Social political orientations; (de)mobilization tendencies
Hong, Chan, and Chiu	Divided societal context Hong Kong, after the 2019 social unrest and the Anti-ELAB movement	2003 Hong Kong residents aged 18 or older (2020)	Social identity approach (SIA) and politicized collective identity	Core values; Legitimacy of the political system; attitudes towards Hong Kong-Mainland China integration	Quantitative: Person-centred analysis using latent class analysis; variable-centred analysis using multiple regressions	Core values; Legitimacy of the political system; attitudes towards Hong Kong-Mainland China integration	Yellow vs. Blue politicized collective identities; collective action intentions; potential solutions to the schism
McKeown, Schaefer, Ali, Dupont, Manley, Rao, Taylor, and Meleady	Divided societal contexts Study 1: Belfast, Northern Ireland Study 2: Bradford, England	Study 1 (Belfast): 231 youth participants ($M_{\text{age, Time1}} = 14.7$ years old) across three time points (2021–2022) Study 2 (Bradford): 159 youth participants ($M_{\text{age, Time1}} = 16.5$ years old) across three time points (2022–2023)	Intergroup contact theory	Outgroup attitudes; Outgroup empathy; intergroup anxiety; outgroup prosocial behaviour	Quantitative: Longitudinal survey (analysis of within- and between-person effects)	Contact quantity; contact quality	Outgroup attitudes; outgroup empathy; intergroup anxiety; outgroup prosocial behaviour

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TABLE 1 | (Continued)

Authors	Context(s)	Sample(s) and year of data collection	Theoretical approach	Operationalization of social cohesion	Method(s) of analysis	Explanans	Explanandum
Këllezi, Wakefield, Bowe, Guxholli, Livingstone, Jetten, and Reicher	Post-conflict contexts Kosovo; Northern Ireland; Albania	Study 1: 23 participants of 6 families of Kosovan Albanians in 4 communities Study 2: 61 participants (survivors of the war) Albania: 27 Albanian participants Kosova: 20 participants (intergroup conflict). All were Albanian Northern Ireland: 14 participants belonging to Protestant/Unionist/Loyalist ($n = 5$) and Catholic/Nationalist/Republican ($n = 8$)	Social identity approach (SIA) and transitional and social justice theories	Study 1: Framing of daily life and survivors' well-being Study 2: Threat to aspects of collective life and collective well-being	Qualitative: Study 1: Ethnography Study 2: In-depth interviews	Study 1: Collective experiences of historical trauma; dissatisfaction with justice frames; dissatisfaction with justice as constant and complex Study 2: Dissatisfaction with justice; survivors' holistic justice perceptions and needs	Study 1: Framing of daily life and survivors' well-being Study 2: Threat to aspects of collective life and collective well-being
Landmann, Unfried, and Restrepo-Plaza	Post-conflict context Colombia	Study 1: 260 university students Study 2: 346 members of the broader Colombian community	Intergroup contact theory	Studies 1 and 2: Reconciliation attitudes	Mixed-method approach: Survey with closed and open-ended questions	Studies 1 and 2: Frequency of positive vs. negative direct, extended, and media-mediated contact (predictor); conflict appraisals (mediator); intergroup emotions (mediator)	Studies 1 and 2: Reconciliation attitudes

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TABLE 1 | (Continued)

Authors	Context(s)	Sample(s) and year of data collection	Theoretical approach	Operationalization of social cohesion	Method(s) of analysis	Explanans	Explanandum
Borinca, Koc, and Mustafa	Post-conflict context Kosovo (intergroup interactions between Kosovo Albanians and Serbs)	Study 1: 251 participants Kosovo Albanian citizens Study 2: 253 participants Kosovo Albanian participants Study 3: 351 participants Kosovo Albanian participants	Justice and reconciliation theories	Perceived genuineness of the apology; willingness for intergroup contact; feelings of peace; support for intergroup negotiations; competitive victimhood	Experimental	Normative apologies; institutional apologies	Perceived genuineness of the apology; willingness for intergroup contact; feelings of peace; support for intergroup negotiations; competitive victimhood
Ivanović, Stanković, and Žeželj	Post-conflict context Serbia	Ten pairs of ethnic Serbian high school seniors (aged 18–19); total = 20 youth participants	Historical narratives and social representation theory	Strategies used to coordinate conflicting historical narratives	Qualitative: Bi-narrative task and post-task interviews	Participants' experience of the task; prior Knowledge; group narratives; history education; historical Knowledge; ethnic identification; willingness for intergroup contact with the Bosniaks	Strategies used to coordinate conflicting historical narratives

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TABLE 1 | (Continued)

Authors	Context(s)	Sample(s) and year of data collection	Theoretical approach	Operationalization of social cohesion	Method(s) of analysis	Explanans	Explanandum
Penić, Elcheroth, and Bilali	Conflict contexts Sri Lanka Occupied Palestinian Territory	Sri Lanka: 1188 participants (representative sample) Occupied Palestinian Territory: 1000 participants (representative sample)	Social/Community cohesion framework	Subjective community cohesion: Community attachment and trust; community efficacy	Quantitative: Standardized face-to-face survey	Vignettes to address knowledge of diverse conflict experiences (predictor); perceived communication norms (moderator) Control variables: conflict victimization; socioeconomic exclusion	Subjective community cohesion: community attachment and trust; community efficacy
Varela, Bulska, Bilali, and Xu	Conflict context Burkina Faso—Sahel Region	Study 1: 5016 participants of the Sahel Region Study 2: 2508 participants (subset of participants from Study 1)	Social cohesion framework: Citizens' vertical relations (with the state) and horizontal relations (with other citizens); ingroup–outgroup dimension	Sense of community; community participation; ingroup trust; outgroup trust; institutional trust; threat; economic grievances	Quantitative: Study 1: Cross-sectional survey Study 2: Longitudinal survey	Predictors: Sense of community; community participation; ingroup trust; outgroup trust; institutional trust; threat; economic grievances Covariates: individual level: gender; age; education; economic grievances; perceived threat from terror attacks Village level: population size; security mark; services index; economic grievances; threat	Justification of extremist violence

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sized serial mediation is not supported. The findings suggest that interventions can target either contact strategies or conflict appraisals to enhance reconciliation. Borinca et al. (2024) report three experimental studies with Kosovo Albanian participants to compare the impact of normative outgroup apologies versus institutional apologies on conciliatory attitudes, intergroup negotiations and competitive victimhood in post-conflict Kosovo. They consistently find that normative apologies from a majority of outgroup members, compared with institutional apologies or a no-apology control condition, lead to greater willingness for intergroup contact, more feelings of peace, stronger support for intergroup negotiations, reduced competitive victimhood and higher humanization of outgroup members. These findings suggest that the majority group's normative apologies are perceived as more genuine, making them powerful tools for improving intergroup relations and reconciliation as indicators of social cohesion.

Ivanović et al. (2024) investigate how 'semantic promoters' (i.e., strategies that group members use in spontaneous peer dialogue) can help create inclusive historical narratives in post-conflict Serbia. Through a qualitative approach using a bi-narrative task and follow-up interviews with pairs of ethnic Serb youths, they show that semantic promoters can generate alternative narratives combining both majority (Serb) and minority outgroup (Bosniak) perspectives. Such narratives challenge exclusionary dominant accounts, promote historical reasoning and may strengthen social cohesion. The findings support the development of educational materials that incorporate inclusive narratives to improve intergroup relations and reconciliation. The contributions so far highlighted have only focused on divided and post-conflict societies. Nonetheless, ongoing conflicts across the world pose particularly serious threats to social cohesion, because such conflict settings do not usually allow for direct intergroup contact or dialogue between conflicting parties and may even be stuck in oppositional dynamics brought by antagonistic perspectives of the conflict and victimization perceptions and dynamics. In this light, conducting research in conflict settings poses several challenges to understanding how ongoing conflict dynamics hinder social cohesion.

Penić et al. (2024) examine two ongoing conflict contexts: Sri Lanka and the Occupied Palestinian Territory. They test whether knowledge of diverse conflict experiences, beyond ingroup victimhood, can foster community cohesion among minority groups facing violence and conflict. Face-to-face surveys with ethnic Tamil participants in Sri Lanka and Palestinian participants in the Occupied Palestinian Territory reveal that such knowledge promotes community cohesion only when it can be discussed openly within the community. When these violent events are perceived as unspeakable, they reduce cohesion. The study highlights the importance of openness and supportive communication norms for discussing diverse experiences of conflict. Varela et al. (2025) study the relationship between multiple dimensions of social cohesion and the justification of extremist violence in the Sahel Region of Burkina Faso, using cross-sectional and longitudinal data. In the study, authors address horizontal (i.e., ingroup trust, sense of community and community participation) and vertical indicators of social cohesion (i.e., institutional trust), both at the individual and community levels. Their results show that most dimensions of social cohesion analysed at the individual level are consistently associated with lower justification of violence. In particular, they find that outgroup trust is a consistent predictor of lower justification of violence across the individual and community levels, both cross-sectionally and longitudinally. Nonetheless, for participants who reside in villages with more community participation (i.e., the frequency with which people attend ingroup community meetings and gatherings), higher levels of outgroup trust are associated with higher support for violence. Between-level comparisons also show that violence justification is lower in villages with stronger aggregate levels of ingroup and outgroup trust, and lower community participation. The results underline the need to differentiate between different social cohesion indicators and levels of analysis when examining their relationship with violence justification.

2.1 | Integrated Summary of Contributions: Similarities Across Contributions

The nine articles in this issue collectively highlight the multifaceted and dynamic nature of social cohesion, along with its indicators, determinants and consequences. These articles also illustrate the diverse ways in which social cohesion is being addressed in divided and (post-)conflict societies. First, a key similarity across the contributions is their shared recognition of the enduring difficulties involved in fostering or maintaining social cohesion, whether through peacebuilding, reconciliation, intergroup contact or efforts to promote unity, during and after periods of violence, conflict or significant social upheaval. Second, the recognition of the multidimensional and multilevel nature of the core concepts analysed across the articles reflects an understanding that social cohesion dynamics are not monolithic but instead consist of various interwoven components that must be analysed to capture their full complexity.

The nine articles also illustrate the varied ways in which social cohesion is defined and operationalized across divided and (post-)conflict contexts, while still reflecting the multidimensional frameworks outlined earlier in the literature. In Lebanon, Al-Amine et al. (2025) conceptualize cohesion through vertical relations (trust and cooperation between citizens and the state) and horizontal relations (trust and cooperation among citizens), linking these to political polarization, sectarianism and institutional trust. Hong et al. (2025), examining Hong Kong during the 2019 unrest, frame cohesion in terms of shared core values, institutional legitimacy and intergroup attitudes between pro- and anti-establishment identities. McKeown et al. (2024), studying youth in Northern Ireland and England, operationalize cohesion as positive intergroup attitudes, empathy, reduced intergroup anxiety and prosocial behaviour—emphasizing the relational and attitudinal aspects of horizontal cohesion. Këllezi et al. (2024), focusing on survivors of MHRVs in Kosovo, Northern Ireland and Albania, approach cohesion via a holistic justice framework, where satisfaction with justice processes sustains both individual and collective well-being. In Colombia, Landmann et al. (2025) define cohesion through reconciliation attitudes towards former combatants, mediated by contact, conflict appraisals and emotions. Borinca et al. (2024), in post-conflict Kosovo, centre cohesion on willingness for contact, negotiation and reduced competitive victimhood, facilitated by normative apologies. Ivanović et al. (2024), in post-conflict Serbia, frame it as the

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capacity to create inclusive historical narratives integrating both ingroup and outgroup perspectives. Penić et al. (2024), working in Sri Lanka and the Occupied Palestinian Territory, define community cohesion as attachment and efficacy, strengthened when diverse conflict experiences can be openly discussed. Finally, Varela et al. (2025) conceptualize cohesion through a sense of community, outgroup trust and institutional trust, examining how these relate to the justification of extremist violence in Burkina Faso's Sahel Region.

Viewed collectively, these operationalizations map closely onto four broad dimensions identified in the literature: (1) social relations (trust, empathy, intergroup contact and reconciliation), (2) connectedness or belonging (community attachment, inclusive narratives and shared values), (3) orientation towards the common good (willingness to negotiate, reduced competitive victimhood and political participation) and (4) territorial bonds (attachment to place or community). Several articles also explicitly integrate the vertical/horizontal distinction, highlighting that cohesion depends not only on interpersonal solidarity but also on institutional trust, thus bridging interpersonal, community and institutional levels of analysis.

Another common thread across the manuscripts is the focus on subjective perceptions, beliefs and narratives in shaping intergroup outcomes. For example, Këllezi et al. (2024) show how survivors' perceptions of holistic justice influence both individual and collective well-being long after conflicts have ended. Ivanović et al. (2024) explore how young people can jointly coordinate conflicting historical narratives and construct more inclusive historical narratives that foster improved intergroup relations and reconciliation. Penić et al. (2024) demonstrate the role of diverse conflict knowledge, openness to discussing conflict experiences and perceived communication norms in fostering community cohesion. Landmann et al. (2025) examine conflict appraisals (i.e., blame, suffering and threat) and emotions as crucial pathways to reconciliation. This shared focus on participants' perceptions, beliefs and narratives underscores how groups' interpretation and communication about their shared past and present significantly impact their ability to coexist and the prospects of improving social cohesion in different contexts.

The need for a social developmental perspective on social cohesion is highlighted by both McKeown et al. 2024 and Ivanović et al. (2024), who specifically target youth populations and suggest a recognition of adolescence as a critical developmental stage in which attitudes and intergroup relations are still being shaped, presenting unique opportunities and challenges for programmes and interventions aimed at fostering social cohesion.

Another important aspect of this collection of articles is the richness and diversity of theoretical frameworks used to analyse social cohesion, reflecting the complexity of the concept and the dynamics of intergroup relations in divided and (post-)conflict societies. For example, previous research in social psychology has examined social cohesion at both structural and individual levels and through a range of theoretical perspectives, such as social identity theory (Baysu et al. 2018; Bilali 2014; McKeown et al. 2016; Uluğ, Bilali, et al. 2021), narratives of conflict and victimhood (Psaltis 2016; Uluğ, Lickel, et al. 2021; Uluğ et al. 2023; Vollhardt et al. 2021), the sociopsychological dimensions of history teaching (Psaltis et al. 2017), hostile versus prosocial intergroup behaviours and political action (Taylor and McKeown 2021), education (Turner et al. 2021) and intergroup contact (Voci et al. 2017; White et al. 2019), among others.

In this special thematic section, this diversity is also showcased. McKeown et al. 2024 and Landmann et al. (2025) draw on intergroup contact theory to examine how different types, quantities and qualities of contact influence attitudes, reconciliation and other social cohesion indicators. Al-Amine et al. (2025) and Varela et al. (2025) explicitly use social cohesion frameworks, operationalizing the concept based on Chan et al.'s (2006) proposal to analyse social cohesion across two dimensions: vertical (state–citizen) and horizontal (citizen–citizen) relations, trust, belonging and participation. Penić et al. (2024) focus on 'community cohesion' as community attachment and efficacy, which aligns with broader social cohesion conceptualizations.

The use of justice and reconciliation theories further highlights the different ways social cohesion can be analysed. Këllezi et al. (2024) offer a unique 'holistic justice' framework that integrates transitional justice (mechanisms addressing past harms such as criminal and reparative justice) and social justice (broader equality and human rights) with the social identity approach to health (SIAH) to understand MHRV survivors' well-being. Borinca et al. (2024) investigate the impact of normative apologies on conciliatory attitudes, aligning with reconciliation literature that examines specific peacebuilding efforts.

In turn, the social identity approach (SIA) appears in the work of Këllezi et al. (2024), who explicitly use it to examine how group memberships influence responses to MHRVs. Hong et al. (2025) adapt theories of collective and politicized identities to explore the ideological bases of group divides that hinder social cohesion in Hong Kong, whereas Al-Amine et al. (2025) examine political partisanship and polarization to understand the group divides that hinder social cohesion in Lebanon. Finally, Ivanović et al. (2024) apply Gillespie's (2008) elaboration of social representations theory (Moscovici 1984, 1988) to examine how conflicting historical narratives are navigated, introducing concepts like semantic promoters as potential facilitators for generating inclusive historical narratives in post-conflict settings.

2.2 | Integrated Summary of Contributions: Differences Between Contributions

In terms of differences, all manuscripts address various dimensions or indicators of social cohesion within divided and (post-)conflict settings. Some focus on community attachment, participation and trust (Penic et al. 2024; Varela et al. 2025), others on attitudes and emotions (Landmann et al. 2025; McKeown et al. 2024), reconciliation-specific indicators like forgiveness, willingness for contact, inclusive or alternative historical narratives (Borinca et al. 2024; Ivanović et al. 2024; Landmann et al. 2025) or on individual and collective well-being (Këllezi et al. 2024). Still others examine the underlying values and political orientations of polarized groups (Al-Amine et al. 2025; Hong et al. 2025). Most studies use these various social cohesion indicators as outcomes in their studies, whereas two studies analyse social cohesion as an antecedent of different social

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phenomena, such as collective politicized identities (Hong et al. 2025) and justification of extremist violence (Varela et al. 2025).

The nature of the (post-)conflicts and/or divisions analysed also varies, ranging from ethno–religious (i.e., Northern Ireland and Kosovo) and ethnic conflicts (Sri Lanka, Palestine and Serbia) to political partisanship (Lebanon and Hong Kong), extremist violence (Burkina Faso) and MHRVs (Albania). This diversity enriches our understanding of social cohesion challenges across different societal fault lines and contexts.

Proposed mechanisms for influencing social cohesion also differ. For example, Borinca et al. (2024) highlight the power of normative apologies and outgroup humanization, whereas Ivanović et al. (2024) identify 'semantic promoters' in dialogue. Penić et al. (2024) emphasize perceived communication norms and diverse conflict knowledge, whereas Landmann et al. (2025) investigate conflict appraisals and emotions.

Methodologically, most manuscripts use surveys (e.g., Al Amine et al. 2025; McKeown et al. 2024), whereas Borinca et al. (2024) employ controlled experiments to test causal links between apology types and social cohesion indicators. Ivanović et al. (2024) use in-depth qualitative dialogical analysis to understand meaning-making processes in navigating conflicting historical narratives and how semantic promoters may foster more inclusive historical narratives that integrate both ingroup and outgroup perspectives. Këllezi et al. (2024) combine ethnography with semi-structured interviews to provide a rich, long-term and context-specific understanding of survivors' well-being after MHRVs.

In summary, these contributions collectively affirm the critical role of perceptions of intra- and intergroup relations and of (in)justice perceptions in shaping social cohesion in divided and (post-)conflict contexts. Although the manuscripts share a common interest in understanding social cohesion and its link to social-psychological processes, their distinct theoretical approaches, methodologies used and specific variables offer complementary insights into the complex pathways through which social cohesion is constructed and influenced over time.

3 | Avenues for Future Research

Considering the overall contributions in this special thematic section, several promising avenues for future research emerge. First, although there is broad recognition of social cohesion as a multifaceted, multidimensional and multilevel concept, it remains difficult to fully grasp it when studied in isolated contexts using narrow theoretical and/or methodological approaches. Social scientists in general and social psychologists in particular should continue working towards clear operational definitions and more interdisciplinary work (e.g., social developmental theorizing) of social cohesion that allow for more precise and parsimonious analysis in different time spans (e.g., micro change in communication and ontogenetic change in development and historical change in longer periods of time; see Wagoner and Psaltis 2025). This includes identifying and analysing the constituent dimensions of social cohesion that are most relevant and informative within specific contexts and differentiating them from social cohesion's correlates. Without such clarity, the concept risks retaining its diffuse and vague nature, leading to fragmented and potentially contradictory and incomplete empirical evidence about how social cohesion evolves, strengthens or erodes over time. In this light, developing more universal definitions and measurement tools should be a priority.

Second, although the contributions in this volume reflect a wide range of contexts, there is still a need to expand and diversify the countries and societies in which social cohesion is studied. This effort should be accompanied by careful attention to context dependence, ensuring that relevant historical, cultural and political factors are integrated into the analysis. Context-dependent variables like the existence of geographical separation of separate language and political communities between groups (e.g., Cyprus) require further theorization as deeply divided societies.

Third, the role of digital media and online interactions in shaping intergroup relations and social cohesion remains underexplored, despite growing evidence of their importance. Future research should incorporate alternative data sources (e.g., web-scraping of publicly available social media content) and methodologies (e.g., participatory research approaches) to improve how social cohesion is conceptualized and measured.

Fourth, more applied research is needed to translate findings about social cohesion into concrete public policy. This includes developing and testing evidence-based programmes and interventions aimed at increasing social cohesion in diverse contexts, particularly in divided and (post-)conflict societies.

To conclude, in today's global social and political climate, several threats to social cohesion are emerging from multiple fronts: ongoing wars and conflicts, including the Russia-Ukraine war, the Sudanese civil war, the conflict in the Democratic Republic of Congo, the Myanmar civil war and the instability in Syria and Lebanon alongside the recent Israeli military attacks on both countries and the destruction and occupation of Gaza with increasing evidence of genocidal acts and the ongoing system of settler-colonialism imposed by Israel on Palestine, pose formidable challenges to cohesion. In such contexts, social cohesion can be extremely difficult. Yet, it remains an urgent priority for research.

At the same time, the rise of populism, authoritarianism and extreme right-wing parties in many countries has intensified political and affective polarization and contributed to the disenfranchisement of citizens. This trend is often accompanied by growing income inequalities and poverty, as well as the undermining of the social and political rights of several minority groups, such as migrants, LGBTQIA+ communities, women and Indigenous peoples. Together, these dynamics pose serious threats to social cohesion and place additional strain on democratic institutions.

Despite these daunting realities, we argue that academics and decision-makers must take up the challenge of deepening our understanding of social cohesion by incorporating diverse perspectives on inclusion and belonging and by embracing diversity, equality and the empowerment of marginalized communities as agents of social change. Such efforts are essential for building more resilient and cohesive societies. We hope that the collec-

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tion of articles in this special thematic section serves both as empirical evidence and as inspiration for scholars to continue exploring the psychological, social, developmental and political dimensions of social cohesion, ultimately contributing to a deeper understanding of its dynamics and to strategies for sustaining and strengthening it across different contexts and over time.

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Conflicts of Interest

The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

Data Availability Statement

This article does not include data.

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